

WE BRING THE VALLEY TO YOU

HEALTH CARE > EFFECTS OF BIG BEAUTIFUL BILL



Photo illustration by Zam Ortega, Walla Walla Union-Bulletin file art

Local health care officials like Shane McGuire, CEO of Columbia County Health System, left, and Medicaid recipients like Beau Currier, right, are grappling with how federal changes to the program will impact health care access. Read Currier's story in a future installment of this series.

'We're going to watch people die'

Local agencies brace for Medicaid changes

SIMMERDEEP KAUR
WALLA WALLA UNION-BULLETIN

For a Walla Walla mother of three who moved to the city to break free from domestic violence, Medicaid is crucial — to cope with depression and provide care for her children.

"It's nice knowing that I can go into the doctors and get immunizations for my kids without having to pay for it or worry about it or have medical bills that are stacking up on me," she said.

She asked that her name not be published because she came to Walla Walla earlier this year to escape an abusive partner — an alcoholic who was constantly in and out of jail — and to protect her children.

"The relationship between us became abusive, not just mentally, but physically," she said. "I just wanted to get out of the situation that I was in." She enrolled in Medicaid about a

month after her move.

She is one of 16,235 Medicaid enrollees in the Walla Walla County. However, state and local officials think this number is about to decline under the Trump administration. The worst hit could be to the most vulnerable populations, including rural communities, people recovering from substance use, formerly incarcerated individuals and the unhoused.

Medicaid is a joint federal and state program that helps cover medical costs for low-income adults, children, pregnant women, older adults and people with disabilities. In Washington, the program is called Apple Health.

The anonymous mother is not currently employed because she does not have child care for her 1-year-old, so she relies on Medicaid to provide health care for her family.



Changes to Medicaid under the Big Beautiful Bill could leave some Walla Walla Valley residents without health insurance. In this ongoing series, we investigate how these policy shifts could affect the most vulnerable populations in our region



Kezia Setyawan, Walla Walla Union-Bulletin

A Medicaid recipient at the STAR Project office who asked not to be identified talks about how the program provides health care for her three kids.

But the benefits of Apple Health in her life extend beyond that — it helps her stay sober. After moving to

Walla Walla, she started therapy at Comprehensive
SEE **MEDICAID** PAGE 4A

Family Medical Center prepares for 'significant' revenue loss ahead of cuts

LORYN KYKENDALL
WALLA WALLA UNION-BULLETIN

The Family Medical Center in Walla Walla is estimating that 10% to 15% of its patient base will lose health coverage at the start of 2027 when expanded Medicaid cuts go into effect.

In Washington and many other states, Medicaid was expanded to single, low-income adults through the Affordable Care Act in 2014. Those expanded benefits are expected to have more restrictive requirements nationwide starting on Jan. 1, 2027.

Christy Trotter, CEO of the Yakima Valley Farm Workers Clinic, which owns the Family Medical Center, said the Walla Walla clinic has about 2,000 patients who are covered by expanded Medicaid benefits. "Now they're going to have to do re-verification of their eligibility every six months as well as meeting community engagement requirements, which would be work, volunteering, things like that," Trotter said.

However, she said the details about how people are going to prove their eligibility and how states are going to process that information is not yet defined.

SEE **CUTS** PAGE 6A



Trotter

CAMPUS FOOTPRINT

Whitman College buys Big House Brew Pub for \$1.5M

JULIA EASTHAM
WALLA WALLA UNION-BULLETIN

Big House Brew Pub, known for its trivia events and selection of beers, burgers and various appetizers, announced on Wednesday, Nov. 19, that it is closing its doors Monday, Dec. 15, and has sold the building to Whitman College.

In a social media post, owners Jason and Denyse Hutchinson thanked the public for

its support and wrote that they have loved being a part of the downtown Walla Walla community.

"We have made many memories, employed so many great people, learned a lot, and wouldn't trade it for anything ... The time has come for us to move on, and the Brew Pub has been sold," Jason and Denyse wrote.

The pair encouraged its customer base

to visit before the closure, use reward points, redeem gift cards and enjoy \$5 pints of craft beer. The restaurant and bar also will have discounts on liquor and swag items.

Since 2018, the pair have owned the building and operated Big House Brew Pub.

SEE **SALE** PAGE 5A

More Information

Big House Brew Pub, 11 S. Palouse St., is open from 11 a.m. to 9 p.m. Sunday through Wednesday; 11 a.m. to 10 p.m. Thursday; and 11 a.m. to 11 p.m. Friday and Saturday. For more information, visit facebook.com/bighousebrewpub.

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